

CARRIER CALLING
An F/A-18 Super Hornet on display at Aero India 2023 in Bengaluru

INDIAN AIR FORCE

- MiG and Sukhoi jets
- Ilyushin IL-76 transport aircraft
- Mi 17, Mi 35, Mi 26 and Kamov helicopters
- Air-to-air and surface-to-air missiles like the R-77, R-37, R-73 ,Kh-59, Kh-35, Kh-31 and KAB laser-guided bombs
- S-400 Triumf surface-to-air missile systems

US PLATFORMS

- Transport planes: C-130J & C-17
- P-8I maritime patrol aircraft
- Apache, Chinook & MH-60R helicopters
- M777 howitzers
- Harpoon missiles

INDIA-US MILITARY TIES HAVE GROWN ON THE BACK OF 'FOUNDATIONAL AGREEMENTS' LIKE THE INDUSTRIAL SECURITY ANNEX

submarines. According to the Stockholm-based defence think-tank SIPRI, Moscow accounted for 60 per cent of all Indian arms imports, totalling $22.9 billion, between 2011 and 2021. And 34 per cent of Russia's defence sales in this period were made to India.

The Indian army runs on Russian hardware: T-90 and T-72 tanks, Konkurs and Korent anti-tank guided missiles and air defence surface-to-air missiles (Osa, Pechora, Strela and the Igla). While the AK 47 assault rifle is widely used, the AK 203, an upgraded version, is being jointly manufactured in India. The Smerch and Grad multiple rocket launcher systems in use with the army are also Russian. T-90 tanks too are now manufactured in India under licence from the Russians without any transfer of technology.

The navy's Russian-origin assets include surface ships (Rajput-class destroyers, Talwar-class frigates and Veer-class missile corvettes), eight kilo-class conventional submarines and the nuclear-powered submarine INS *Chakra*.

The IAF operates the MiG series as well as Sukhoi fighter jets, and Ilyushin IL-76 transport aircraft. The world's fourth largest air force is also dependent on Russian Mi 17, Mi 35, Mi 26 and Kamov helicopters. The majority of IAF's firepower comes from Russian air-to-air and surface-to-air missiles like the R-77, R-37, R-73,Kh-59, Kh-35, Kh-31 and KAB laser-guided bombs, along with S-400 Triumf surface-to-air missile systems. Five regiments of the S-400 are expected to be delivered by the end of 2024.

Yury B. Slyusar, general director of UAC, which produces the Sukhoi and MiG jets, says that Russia will continue to be a reliable partner of India. Recently, UAC has proposed to manufacture its 100-seater Sukhoi Superjet civil aircraft in India with Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL). "India is a long-standing partner, and a large number of Russian equipment is operated here. We will continue to cooperate amidst challenges," Yury says. He did not mention offering the latest Sukhoi -57 and Sukhoi-75 stealth fighter jets to India, which may bring Russia back into the spotlight in the Indian defence arena.

The task before India is to nurture the close defence alliance with the US while balancing it with the certainty of Russia being a trusted ally and supplier of hardware. Indian military planners may be sceptical about US intentions, what with its military aid to Pakistan, like the recent $450 million grant to upgrade the PAF's F-16 jets. But, with China looming across the LAC, it becomes crucial for India to keep Washington on its side. A South Block official believes that having US platforms will cut dependency on Russia and diversify the Indian military's inventory. India, for sure, is also buying arms from other European nations, like the Rafale jets from France. Washington, too, knows that it isn't easy to wish Russia away from the Indian military market. Along with all this, India needs to create a defence innovation base and ecosystem by supporting and encouraging the private sector and start-ups. ■